> It has not always been easy to be Jewish in America, especially for those of us growing up in smaller cities—like Peoria—where you were very marginal as Jews. . . . There was some kind of an attempt to distance yourself from that painful experience. People changed their names and did something to their noses, tried not to talk with their hands, sometimes even used canned peas, and denied the very richness, the warmth, the specialness, the good taste of their own background as Jews.[11]

Today, Israel is the only place where Jews need not hide themselves as Jews. It was one of the Herzl's dreams:

> In the Promised Land, we will be able to walk tall without being jeered for our hooked noses, black or red beard, or bowlegged gait. A country where the Jews would not feel like strangers, stigmatized, and caricaturized. . . . There we will finally be able to live as a free people in our own land and die quietly in our homeland. There we will also be granted respect for great achievements.[12]

JEWISH IDENTITY, SOLIDARITY

At a time when Jews are integrated among the nations, the concept of identity has become a major concern for Jewish leaders. In the ghetto, there was no asking "who is a Jew?" Secularization blunted the certainties of Jewish identity and made necessary new expressions to define it. Today, people talk about assimilation and a "decline" in Jewish identity, diversity, fractured and hybrid identities. When the borders between groups are perceived as fluid and porous, group integrity is weakened.

However, Jewish history has shown that assimilation does not always allow people to escape their origins. Holocaust memory raised the issue of how far Jews are able to assimilate in other nations, and above all the impossibility of "escaping one's Jewish destiny."

And if we refer to a shared destiny, then we also refer to solidarity, responsibility, and unity. Confronted by the Nazis' racial antisemitism, the Jewish philosopher Emmanuel Levinas understood that it was impossible to escape the Jewish condition. Hence he gladly accepts it by an "unexpected turning of the curse into rapture."[13] So, assimilation turns out to be only an illusion: being Jewish supposes inassimilable qualities. We have then to rethink, to reinvent Jewish identity after the experience of the Shoah.

The Holocaust has reinforced also a need for Jewish continuity and survival. If Hitler did not manage to wipe out the entire Jewish people, then the Jewish people must not be allowed to disappear as a result of

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